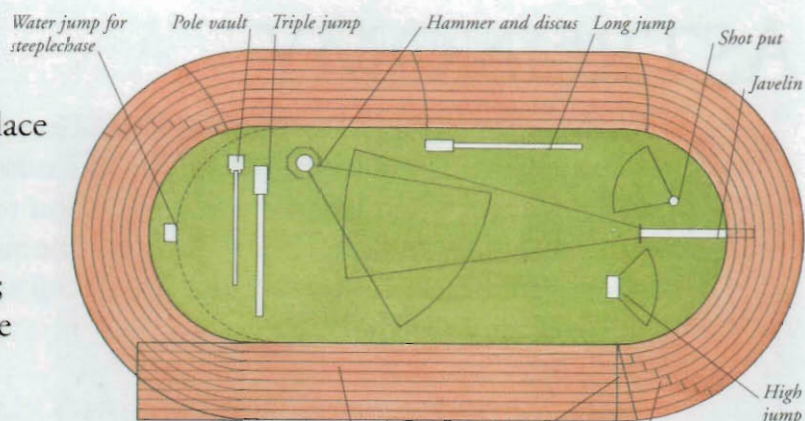


ATHLETICS



THIS POPULAR SPORT takes place mainly in a stadium where it is divided into two main categories: track and field.

Track includes running and hurdling races; field includes jumping and throwing. Some athletics events involve more than one discipline – 10 in the decathlon for men; seven in the heptathlon for women. Other events are road and cross-country running. Major competitions are the Olympics and world and continental championships.



Athletics stadium

In an athletics stadium, there is a 400-m (437-yd) running track, usually marked with eight lanes. The field events take place in special areas on the grass area inside the track.

The 100-m sprint, 100-m hurdles, and 110-m hurdles are the only races run in a straight line.

The finish line is in the same place for all races.

Races around bends have a staggered start which means athletes do not start in a straight line.

Track events

Racing takes place on the flat and over hurdles. Competitors in events up to 400 m have to stay in their lane for the whole race. The 800 m is run in lanes until the end of the first bend. A photo-finish camera is used to determine final places, and runners are timed to 0.01 seconds.



Hurdling

Athletes have to negotiate 10 hurdles in all the races – 100 m for women, 110 m for men, and 400 m for men and women. In the 3,000-m steeplechase, runners take four hurdles and the water jump on each full lap. They all use the same, fixed hurdles.

Running

Races on the track range from 100 m to the 25-lap 10,000 m. Runners use starting blocks for races from 100 m to 400 m. There are two standard relay races: 4 by 100 m and 4 by 400 m, with team members passing a baton.

Jumping events

There are four jumping events. In the high jump and pole vault, the bar is gradually raised. Competitors are eliminated if they have three consecutive failures. In the long jump and triple jump, competitors have a set number of attempts, the best one counting. The triple jump is a hop, step, and jump.



Pole vault

Poles, usually made of fibreglass, may be of any size. The vaulter plants the pole in a sunken box at the end of the run-up before taking off. The pole bends and then straightens as the vaulter tries to clear the bar feet first, releasing the pole.

Long jump

Competitors must take off before the end of a wooden take-off board sunk into the run-up. The jump is measured from the end of the board to the nearest part of the sand disturbed by the competitor with any part of the body, hands, or legs.



Carl Lewis

In 1984, American Carl Lewis (b. 1961) won Olympic golds in the 100 m, 200 m, 4-by-100-m relay, and the long jump. He won five more gold medals in later Olympics and retained his long-jump title three times (1988–96), becoming only the second athlete in history to win four golds in one event.



Throwing events

In the shot put, discus, and hammer, competitors throw from special circles. In the javelin, they throw from behind a curved line at the end of a run-up.



The marathon

This road race is 42.195 km (26.2 miles) long. Some major races start and finish in the stadium. It derives from the Battle of Marathon in 490 BC, when a messenger ran to Athens with news of the Athenian victory over the Persians.



Javelin distances are measured to where the tip first hits the ground. It does not have to stick.

Shot is a metal sphere weighing 7.26 kg (16 lb) for men and 4 kg (8.8 lb) for women. It is "put" with one pushing action.

Hammer is a metal sphere fixed to a handle by steel wire. Most people turn three or four times before releasing the hammer.

Discus has a metal rim with a weight at the centre. Like the hammer, the discus is thrown from a cage for safety reasons.



Shot



Discus

Javelin



High jump

Most high jumpers use the Fosbury flop technique, which involves turning at take-off to pass head first and face up over the bar. Competitors are not allowed to take off from both feet together.

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